

TEACHING SCRIPT | LESSON 5

Galatians, Part 2

A 50-minute teaching script for Galatians 3–6

BIG IDEA Those justified by faith are free to live by the Spirit in love rather than return to slavery.

BEFORE CLASS Write on the board: What has Christ freed us from—and what has he freed us for? Have Galatians 3:23–29; 4:4–7; 5:1–6; and 5:13–26 marked for one reader.

0:00–4:00 | Welcome, prayer, and Lesson 4 recap

Good morning. Last week we heard Paul insist that there is no “gospel plus.” The gospel came from God, and God declares sinners right through faith in Christ—not through works of the law. We also saw that this doctrine reaches the church’s table: Peter’s withdrawal from Gentile believers communicated that Christ was not enough for full fellowship.

Today Paul answers the next question. If obedience does not earn our standing before God, what produces a holy life? And what exactly has Christ’s freedom freed us to do?

Let’s pray. Father, thank you that in Christ you receive us as children and heirs. Give us your Spirit. Keep us from both religious self-reliance and self-centered freedom. Form in us the life of Jesus, and teach us to serve one another in love. Amen.

4:00–7:00 | Orient the class to Galatians 3–6

Only some of us may have finished all four chapters, so let me give us the road map. In chapters 3 and 4 Paul explains promise, law, faith, and adoption. In chapter 5 he calls believers to stand firm in freedom and walk by the Spirit. In chapter 6 he shows what that Spirit-shaped freedom looks like in a congregation.

Our board question will guide the hour: What has Christ freed us from—and what has he freed us for?

7:00–10:00 | Read Galatians 3:23–29 and 4:4–7

Ask one reader to read Galatians 3:23–29 and then 4:4–7. Ask everyone to listen for changes in identity: guardian to faith, children of God, clothed with Christ, heirs according to promise, slave to son.

10:00–14:00 | Promise, law, and the family of Abraham

Paul reaches behind Moses to Abraham. God promised Abraham that blessing would come to the nations through his offspring. The law came later and did not cancel that promise.

Then Paul asks, “Why, then, was the law given at all?” His answer is compressed. It was added because of transgressions until the promised Seed came. It exposed sin, held everything under sin, and served as a guardian until Christ. The law could name the good and restrain evil, but it could not give the Spirit, create life, or deliver the inheritance.

Paul speaks of Abraham’s “seed.” The word can name one descendant or a collective family. Paul’s point is not a clever grammatical trick. God’s promise comes to its focus and fulfillment in Christ. If we belong to Christ, then what is true of Christ becomes ours: we are Abraham’s seed and heirs according to the promise.

And notice the family language. In Christ, all are children of God through faith. In the ancient world “son” was inheritance language, and Paul explicitly says male and female share the same identity in Christ. God sends the Spirit of his Son into our hearts, crying, “Abba, Father.” Grace does not merely erase a guilty verdict. God brings us home as children and heirs.

ASK How does belonging to Christ answer the question, “Who belongs to Abraham’s family?”

14:00–17:00 | Summarize Hagar and Sarah

Say: In Galatians 4:21–31 Paul gives a difficult, figurative reading of Hagar and Sarah. Hagar corresponds to Sinai, the present Jerusalem, and slavery. Sarah corresponds to God’s promise, the Jerusalem above, and freedom. Paul is warning Gentile believers not to seek secure family status by placing themselves under the law.

We should not reduce the passage to “Hagar was the human plan and Sarah was God’s plan.” In Genesis, Sarah herself proposed the Hagar arrangement. Paul tells us the correspondences he wants us to see: slavery versus promise and freedom. We should stay with his argument and avoid inventing a meaning for every detail.

17:00–22:00 | Read and teach Galatians 5:1–6

Ask the reader to read Galatians 5:1–6.

“It is for freedom that Christ has set us free.” This may sound familiar after the sermon series we just completed. Paul’s command to stand firm begins with something Christ has already done. We do not stand firm by manufacturing enough spiritual toughness. We stand in the freedom Christ won, as God’s children who have received the Spirit.

The image is a yoke of slavery. Many Jewish people could speak positively about Torah as God’s gracious gift—a yoke that ordered life under God. Paul is not caricaturing every Jewish person as miserable under a terrible law. He is opposing the demand that Gentile believers take on circumcision and the law as the basis of justification and full covenant standing. That is why Acts 15:10 is such a close parallel: Peter refuses to place that yoke upon Gentile believers.

Paul’s warning in verses 2–4 is severe. If circumcision is accepted on those terms, the person is obligated to obey the whole law and is trying to be justified by law. Later Jewish tradition counted 613 commandments, but Paul does not need that number. His own point is that the law is a whole and cannot become a selective staircase to righteousness.

“Fallen away from grace” in verse 4 is not a label for every ordinary sin, failure, or season of doubt. In this context Paul is addressing the specific attempt to leave grace as the ground of justification and seek that verdict through law.

Verse 6 gives the alternative: “faith expressing itself through love.” Faith alone receives Christ, but living faith is not barren. Grace produces love.

22:00–25:00 | Read Galatians 5:13–26

Ask the reader to read Galatians 5:13–26. Ask the class to listen for two wrong paths, two opposing sources of desire, and two kinds of communal result.

25:00–35:00 | Freedom, love, flesh, and Spirit

Christian freedom has two enemies. The first is legalism: using obedience, religious identity, or performance to establish our standing before God. The second is license: using freedom as permission to center ourselves and indulge desires that destroy others. Paul rejects both.

We are free from earning God’s verdict and from the domination of sin so that we may “serve one another humbly in love.” Paul even uses the language of slavery: do not return to slavery under law, but freely become servants of one another in love. The whole law is fulfilled in “Love your neighbor as yourself.”

We sometimes say *agapē* means a uniquely divine kind of love. We should be more careful. Greek words receive their meaning from context; *agapē* is not a magic technical term. Here Paul describes active, self-giving, neighbor-serving love shaped by Christ—not merely warm feeling, approval, or avoiding hard truth.

What does Paul mean by “flesh”? He does not mean our physical bodies are evil. “Flesh” here is fallen, self-directed human life resisting God. Look at the results: sexual disorder, false worship, hatred, rivalry, jealousy, rage, selfish ambition, division, envy, drunkenness. Many of those works do not stay private. They consume communities.

The Spirit produces a different harvest: love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control. This is not a set of nine boxes we complete to earn acceptance. It is the Spirit forming the character of Christ in a people who already belong to Christ.

Walking by the Spirit is neither passive nor self-powered. Paul says “walk,” “be led,” and “keep in step.” The Spirit gives life and power; believers actively listen, yield, refuse destructive desires, and practice the next faithful step.

ASK Which items in the works of the flesh are easiest to excuse in churches because they can look respectable?

35:00–39:00 | Read selected verses from Galatians 6

Ask the reader to read Galatians 6:1–2, 7–10, and 14–15. Ask everyone to notice what Spirit-shaped people do together and what Paul refuses to boast in.

39:00–43:00 | The Spirit creates a burden-bearing church

Chapter 6 keeps the fruit of the Spirit from becoming a private personality test. If someone is caught in sin, spiritual people restore that person gently—and watch themselves. Gentleness is not pretending sin does not matter. It is pursuing restoration without pride or cruelty.

Believers carry one another’s burdens and so fulfill the law of Christ. A few verses later Paul says each person should carry their own load. Those are not contradictions. We take responsibility for our work, and when a burden becomes crushing, the church comes alongside.

Sowing to the Spirit means persevering in concrete goodness even when results are slow. And Paul closes by refusing to boast in religious status. Neither circumcision nor uncircumcision is the badge that counts. What counts is new creation. The cross ends boasting; the Spirit begins a new humanity.

43:00–47:00 | The Gospel Then and Now

Return to the board: What has Christ freed us from—and what has he freed us for?

In Galatia, believers were tempted to seek secure status through circumcision and law observance. They were also tempted to bite and devour one another, to indulge the flesh, and to become conceited, provoking and envying one another.

Churches now can fall into either ditch. We can build confidence on doctrinal résumé, moral record, political identity, ministry success, or tradition. Or we can call self-indulgence “freedom” and excuse rivalry, anger, division, or harm.

A gospel-shaped church stands in Christ’s finished work and walks by the Spirit. It serves in love, restores gently, carries burdens, resists rivalry, perseveres in goodness, and boasts only in the cross.

DISCUSS How can a congregation teach serious obedience without turning obedience into the price of belonging?

Follow-up if time: What is one burden Christians are tempted to tell people to carry alone?

47:00–50:00 | Summary, next reading, and prayer

Today Paul took us from promise to family, from family to freedom, and from freedom to life by the Spirit. The law could expose and guard, but it could not give life. Christ fulfilled the promise, made us children and heirs, and gave us the Spirit. Therefore freedom is neither a new ladder for proving ourselves nor permission to live for ourselves. It is freedom to love.

FINAL LINE Christ set us free from earning our place so that, by the Spirit, we may take our place in a family that serves, restores, and carries burdens in love.

Before next week, start with Acts 17:1–10 and 1 Thessalonians 1. If possible, continue through 1 Thessalonians 2–3. Notice how the Thessalonians received the gospel under pressure and what Paul praises about their changed life.

Let’s pray. Father, thank you that Christ has set us free and made us your children. Keep us standing in grace. Crucify the desires that destroy us and our neighbors. By your Spirit, grow the life of Christ among us, teach us to carry one another’s burdens, and make us a new-creation people who boast only in the cross. Amen.